

Assurance

This lesson is the second in the series entitled “The Beginner’s Bible Study.” Other lessons in this series can be obtained through the Lehigh Valley Baptist Church.

The lessons are designed to be first studied, then the questions in the back answered, and then reviewed with the help of an older Christian.

***“As ye have therefore received Christ Jesus
the Lord, so walk ye in Him.”***

Colossians 2:6

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One of the most often asked questions from a new Christian is “How do I know that I am saved? Can I be sure of such a thing?” One of the most disputed facts today in religious circles is if a person can really be sure that when they die, they are going to heaven.

We began this Beginner’s Bible Study with the matter of SALVATION. Now we are going to talk about ASSURANCE of salvation. We are asking the question, “Can a person know that when they die they are going to Heaven? Can they be sure? Can they be positive about their eternal destination? Is that really a possibility?”

WE HAVE ASSURANCE

In I John 5:13 we read, *“These things have I written unto you that believe on the name of the Son of God, that ye may know that you have eternal life and that ye may believe on the name of the Son of God.”* The apostle John writes that a person can know. The word that he uses there for know is an absolute assurance, an absolute “know so” kind of knowing. He says we can know that we have eternal life. We can know that we have a home in Heaven. We can know that we have a relationship with the Father.

The apostle Paul says much the same thing in a different way when he writes in II Corinthians 13:5, *“Examine yourselves whether ye be in the faith, prove your own selves, know ye not your own selves how that Jesus Christ is in you except ye be reprobates.”* What does he mean? He means that it is possible for a person to examine himself and be sure that he is in the faith. But it is also possible for a person to think he is in the faith and not to be. Therefore he tells us to examine ourselves.

The apostle Peter writes in I Peter 3:15 that we ought always to be ready to give answer for the reason of the hope that lies within us. *“But sanctify the Lord God in your hearts, and be ready always to give an answer to every man that asketh you a reason of the hope that is in you with meekness and fear.”*

What hope is he talking about? He is talking about this “know so” kind of salvation that John talked about. He is talking about this examining of ourselves and of being able to say, “I am in the faith.” He is saying, “If you can say that, if you can have that kind of hope, then you ought to be ready to give an answer for it, you ought to be ready to give a reason why you believe you are a child of God.”

The sad part is that there are many people who think that they are saved and they are not. Jesus Christ makes that clear in Matthew 7. He says there will be a day when people will stand before the Lord and say, “Lord, Lord, have we not done many mighty works in your name?” And Christ will say to them, “Depart from me. I never knew you. You were never a child of God, and you are not one of mine now.” It is possible for a person to think that they are a Christian, and to think that they are going to Heaven and not really be saved.

The Bible tells us in John 8:44 that Satan is a liar and the father of all lies. In Genesis 3:1 we see where the devil, embodied in a serpent, talks to Eve. He asks to her, “Yea, hath God said? Can you really trust God? Do you really believe God?”

Now, for those of you who have known Christ any length of time, there has probably been a time since you’ve been saved that you have said, “I wonder if I am really a Christian? I wonder if I have

been born again?” There have been times when you have questioned your salvation because Satan does whisper those lies in your ear like he does in mine. “How can you be a Christian? How can you be so sure?”

If you are out in this world long enough brushing elbows with folks that do not know Christ, they will keep telling you, “Nobody can know. Nobody can be sure.” If you are not feeding yourself with the Word of God you are going to start questioning your salvation. If you don’t know what God has said and if you are not rooted and grounded in the Word of Truth, you are going to come away scratching your head saying, “Maybe I’ve talked myself into something that isn’t real. Maybe I have fed myself a line and maybe I believed something that I really have no reason to believe.”

So we ask ourselves the question, “Can a person really know?” And we have already read the answer to that in I John 5. The reason I have written these things to you, he says, is so you may know that you have eternal life. I don’t want you guessing or hoping or wishing or not positive about this thing. I want you to know.

THE FRUITS OF ASSURANCE

What are the fruits of assurance of salvation? What good does it do to know you are saved? There are some practical things God gives us because we know we are saved.

We have joy in assurance.

In I John 5:13, John tells us the reason he was writing the epistle was that we may know that we are saved. Another part of that reason is

found in I John 1:4, “*And these things we write unto you that your joy may be full.*” If you have been born again, but you do not have assurance of salvation, then you are going to be robbed of your joy. If you are not sure according to God’s Word that you have been born again, then you are going to be robbed of your joy. You are not going to have joy in this life. You are going to have a hard time having joy in this life, especially when things begin to go against you and you take a look around and say, “I don’t have the things of life that I would like to have.” Where are you going to find your joy at a time like that?

The child of God can lose everything he has and watch it all slip through his fingers, yet he can still have joy. Why? Because he still has not lost the most valuable thing in all of his life. He may have lost his bank account, his wife, his kids, his house and his job. He may have lost everything that this world has for him. But one thing can’t be taken away from you if you know you have been born again. Your joy cannot be taken away because you know you have eternal life that can’t slip away.

We have peace and comfort in assurance.

In another passage of scripture, I John 3:19-21, we read, “*And hereby we know that we are of the truth, and shall assure our hearts before Him...Beloved, if our heart condemn us not, then have we confidence toward God.*” There is an assurance. There is a peace and a comfort that goes along with that. Though the rest of the world may turn their back, and the rest of the world may ridicule and laugh at the things of God, we still know that the Bible is true and our God is true, and our salvation is real. We have an assurance.

That is why many of our forefathers were able to sit in prison knowing that they were about to lose their life. When they were given their last chance to recant and turn their back on Christ, they boldly cried, “I will not deny Him! Kill me if you will, but I will not deny Him.”

Children were taken outside and mothers and fathers were told, “You either deny Christ or your children are going to be thrown to these wild pigs.” Now, what would you do at a time like that? The mothers and fathers said, “We will not turn our backs on Jesus Christ.” Then the babies were taken and thrown to the pigs and eaten in front of their parents. Can you imagine that? Can you imagine watching your child—your baby that you’ve given birth to—taken and eaten by wild animals? Yet that happened to some of our forefathers.

How in the world could they stand there and watch such a thing take place? I say to you, it’s because they had a comfort and an assurance, that something that was real to them even in the midst of losing their own children. They had the assurance of knowing God was real. Even in the midst of being literally burned at the stake, or having their intestines ripped out and dying for the faith of Jesus Christ, they were able to stand there and stay steadfast. They had an assurance that was more real than any kind of assurance that any world-power could give them.

We have stability in assurance.

There is a third thing here in James 1:8. “*A double minded man is unstable in all his ways.*” I submit to you that a person who has assurance of their salvation has stability to their life. They don’t

have to be afraid when it comes time to die. They don't have to sit there and wonder or worry. I am not saying that death doesn't hold any fear, but I am saying that death will not cause a child of God who has his mind and heart stayed on the Lord to be shaken. It will not shake his faith.

I like what was said of the Methodists early on (I am not sure who said it but it was said to Wesley), "You know, there is one thing that has impressed us about you Methodists. Your people die well." The thing that ought to impress people about our faith is that we do die well.

We live in a day and age when we pump tranquilizers and painkillers into people so that they just lay there and when they die, we don't know what death is all about. But I have been at the deathbed of dying people who knew Jesus Christ. I have been there when they died without painkillers. I have seen them as they breathed their last breath and they're gone. And I have seen a difference between their death and the death of those who do not know Jesus Christ. There is a major difference in the way they die. There is a difference in the peace that's on the face and the peace that's in the heart and the voice of a child of God who is going out to meet the Lord Jesus Christ.

There is a difference between them and the person who goes out into eternity screaming because he fears where he is going. He has no assurance. Now, I realize that our painkillers have numbed that, but there are still a few people in our world who do pass away without the aid of the doctors pumping them full of all kinds of tranquilizers. I think we ought to go back to that. Not because we are inhumane, but I believe it gives people another chance to get saved in those last few moments. If you dope them up what chance do they have?

THE BASIS OF ASSURANCE: THE WORD OF GOD

How can I know that I'm saved? If it is going to give me joy in my Christian life, how in the world do I get it? How can I be sure? What is the basis of my assurance?

In I John 5:11-13 the Bible says, *"And this is the record, that God hath given to us eternal life, and this life is in His Son. He that hath the Son hath life; and he that hath not the Son of God hath not life. These things have I written unto you that believe on the name of the Son of God; that ye may know that ye have eternal life, and that ye may believe on the name of the Son of God."* Now, in verse 11 he tells us *"This is the record..."* What is the record? It is the Word of God. This book is the record.

Then he says in verse 13, *"These things have I written unto you that believe on the name of the Son of God; that ye may know that ye have eternal life."* In other words John is saying we have a record which we hold in our hands which is the basis—the foundation—the proof that our eternal life is real. It is from the Bible that we gain our assurance. It is from this Book that we get our basis of knowing that we are a child of God.

In our world it is normal and accepted behavior to base the fact that you are going to heaven on "I feel like it." That is the way most people think about it. But you'll not find any kind of statements like that in the Bible. In fact, it is possible for a person not to feel like they are saved and still be saved because feeling has nothing to do with it. It's not what I think, and by the way, it's not what any preacher says. It is not what any church says. But if I am going to be

saved, I am going to be saved according to what the Bible says. If I have assurance of salvation, and I know that when I die I am going to heaven, I am only going to be able to have a God-given assurance of salvation.

I am able to compare this book with my life and say that what the Bible says about salvation is what has happened to me. If I can't say that, then I have no right to say to anybody, "I know I've been born again." That is why Peter said, "*Be ready always to give an answer to every man that asketh you a reason of the hope that is in you.*" That is what Paul meant when he said in II Corinthians 13 "*Examine yourselves.*" Examine myself? Do I get out a microscope and turn it inward? Am I supposed to cut myself open and look at myself and take pictures of my brain? Will that show me anything? The answer is no, you won't get anything. We can't examine ourselves unless we have the correct instrument of examination, and that is the Bible.

Salvation is not only a Baptist teaching. It's not by being a Baptist that you get to heaven. Thank God that Baptists preach salvation by grace through faith. I wish the Methodists, or the Lutherans, or some other 'religious groups' would preach the correct way to be saved besides the Baptists.

But salvation is not because you are a Baptist. Salvation is not because you've joined any kind of a church. I don't care what brand or denomination you want to put on it. I don't care if you have been baptized. That does not give you salvation. So we must find out what salvation is. Let's look at what God says. The basis of assurance is the Word of God and there are three things that I want you to see.

The Promise of God

First we have the promise of God, the written record that God has given us. If I have been saved, and I have eternal life, I am going to be able to look in the Bible and find a reason why. I am going to be able to prove it from the Bible.

The promise is for right now.

In John 5:24 he says, “*Verily, verily, I say unto you, He that heareth my word, and believeth on him that sent me, hath everlasting life, and shall not come into condemnation; but is passed from death unto life.*” Now here is the promise of Jesus Christ: The person who listens to what I have to say and believes on Him that sent me, putting your full faith and trust in me will have (present tense, right now) everlasting life. It’s not something you are going to get when you die. It’s something that you have right now.

We have passed from death to life.

Then, you will have passed (past tense, this happened when you believed) from condemnation to life. Here is His promise—if we have believed on Him and listened to His words, then Jesus Christ has translated us out of a state of condemnation. God was ready to say, “You deserve to go to Hell. Go to Hell!” Jesus has put us in a place where He says, “Enter into my kingdom, you belong to me.”

How do I know I have been born again? I know by the promise of God. If I have heard His Word and believed on Him, then Jesus Christ says I have passed from death unto life. I have been changed. It doesn’t matter what I look like and it doesn’t matter what I feel like, but it does matter what God says. He says I passed from death to life. That is His testimony. I will remind you, God can’t lie.

We will never be cast out.

Here is another promise in John 6:37, “*All that the Father giveth me shall come to me; and him that cometh to me I will in no wise cast out.*” How do I know that I am a child of God and how do I know that I’m born again? I ask myself the question, “Have I come to Him?” If I have come to Him, will He cast me out? Absolutely not! Will He say no to me? Will He turn me away? Will He bar the doors? Will He say to me, “Doug Hammett, I’m sick of you, Out of here!” No sir! No way! He says He will in no wise, for no reason, absolutely none, cast me out.

No one can pluck us from God’s hands.

In another passage of scripture, John 10:27 says, “*My sheep hear my voice, and I know them, and they follow me: And I give unto them eternal life; and they shall never perish, neither shall any man pluck them out of my hand. My Father, which gave them me, is greater than all; and no man is able to pluck them out of my Father’s hand.*” The Bible is telling me in verse 27 that if I have heard His Word, I belong to Him. Now listen carefully: If I have heard His Word, if I have become one of His sheep, the next step is that I am going to follow Him.

In other words, a child of God who has heard His Word and become His child will have not only heard it with his physical ears, but he will have heard it with his spiritual ears, and he will be following Jesus Christ. If he has heard the Word and is following Jesus Christ, listen to what He promises. In verse 28 He says, “*I give them eternal life, and no man shall pluck them out of my Father’s hand.*” Nobody can snatch them away or in any way make them lose what they have. There is the promise of God.

We are no longer condemned.

In Romans 8:1 the Bible says, *“There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus, who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit.”* The Bible says that there is no condemnation as a child of God if I am in Jesus Christ. How do you get into Him? You get into Him by believing on Him, by trusting Him, by receiving Him, by being born again.

If I have received Jesus Christ, then here is the promise of God: *“There is therefore now no condemnation.”* God will not condemn me. He cannot condemn me if I am in Jesus Christ. He cannot say to me, “Doug Hammett, you have sinned too much, off to Hell with you!” He cannot do that for He has promised that I will not, **cannot** be condemned.

In verses 38 and 39 of the same chapter he says, *“For I am persuaded, that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor principalities, nor powers, nor things present, nor things to come, nor height, nor depth, nor any other creature, shall be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.”* The Bible says I cannot be separated from Christ. If I have received Him on His terms, then He has received me. He cannot cast me out and neither can anything else separate me from His love. Nothing can rip me out of His arms. Absolutely nothing.

We are kept by God.

Lastly in regard to our promises we read in I Peter 1:3-5, *“Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, which according to his abundant mercy hath begotten us again unto a lively hope by the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance incorruptible, and undefiled, and that fadeth not away, reserved in*

heaven for you who are kept by the power of God through faith unto salvation ready to be revealed in the last time.”

If you and I have believed on Jesus Christ, if we have received Jesus Christ, if we have been born again, if we have accepted Him, if we have committed ourselves to Him, if we have called upon Him—then the Bible says we are kept. We are kept not by our own power, not by our own ability or by our own strength or our own emotions or anything else. We aren’t even kept by our own faith. We are kept by His power. He is the one who does the keeping. And it is only fitting, because He is the one who did the saving to begin with!

Here is a problem that a lot of young converts wrestle with. “Okay, I asked Christ into my heart, but how do I know that he really accepted me? How do I know that He’ll really keep me? How can I be sure that I am going to be saved and stay saved?” And the answer is because of the promises of God. If you have heard His Word, John 5:24, and believed on Him, then He promises that you have passed from death unto life. He promises that you do have, right now, eternal life. You can’t lose it. He keeps you, according to I Peter. So we have the promises of God.

The Presence of God

What is a second reason that I can I be sure that I have been born again? If I am saved I have the presence of God. In Romans 5:5 we read, *“And hope maketh not ashamed; because the love of God is shed abroad in our hearts by the Holy Ghost which is given unto us. This is the presence of God.”* The Holy Spirit comes to live inside of us when we are born again.

In Romans 8:16 it reads, *“The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit, that we are the children of God.”* Here is God’s presence.

We have the promise that if we have believed on Him, He guarantees us eternal life. But the problem that we have is knowing, “Have I really believed on Him? Can I be satisfied that I have really received Him?” And the way that we know is because He has given us the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit dwells inside of us. It’s not some “heeby-geeby” kind of a thing. It’s not some kind of feeling of goose bumps up and down the back of your spine. It’s not your hair standing up on end. It’s not some vision.

According to John 16, the Bible tells us how the Holy Spirit bears witness with us. What is His job? He lives inside of us for what purpose? John 16:13 says, *“Howbeit, when he, the Spirit of truth, is come, he will guide you into all truth: for he shall not speak of himself; but whatsoever he shall hear, that shall he speak: and he will shew you things to come.”*

What does the Holy Spirit speak about? Truth. What is truth? *“Thy word is truth.”* It’s the Word of God. How does the Holy Spirit of God bear witness with my spirit? He bears witness with my spirit as I get into the Bible, and I search out from the Bible, “What has God said about salvation?”

As I read what God says about salvation and receiving Christ and knowing that I’ve been born again, the Holy Spirit of God is inside of me, if I am a child of God. He is saying to me, “Doug Hammett, you have believed, Doug Hammett, you have received me, Doug Hammett, you have been born again, Doug Hammett, you have

committed your life, Doug Hammett, you have called on Jesus Christ.”

That’s how I know that I am born again. Not just the promises of God, for the promises of God could be in general, they may not be to me personally. But the presence of God is a personal thing. The Spirit of God lives inside of me and as I read the Bible it opens up to me, and speaks to me, and says, “Doug Hammett, this is you.”

So I ask myself the question, “Have I repented, have I received Christ?” And as I read the scriptures, the Spirit of God says, “Yes, Doug. Yes, Doug, you have received Christ. Remember the day you believed. You have sorrowed over your sins. And you have believed on Christ alone and trusted in Him alone for that salvation that only He can give.”

The Power of God

There is a third way that we know we are saved. We have the promise of God and the presence of God, but a person could still be baffled or bewildered, and still, sad to say, could trip themselves up and think they are saved when they are not. So God has given us the power of God. II Corinthians 5:17 tells us, “*Therefore if any man be in Christ, he is a new creature: old things are passed away, behold, all things are become new.*” The power of God very simply says that when a person gets saved God is going to begin to work in his life over a period of time, and there is going to be some changes that take place.

We could spend all night going through verses on this, but in Philippians 1:6 it says, “*Being confident of this very thing, that he*

which hath begun a good work in you will perform it until the day of Jesus Christ.” If I have been born again, there is one thing that is guaranteed in my life. From the day of my salvation until the day of my physical death, Doug Hammett is going to be changed and changing.

No, I was not perfect the day I got saved. But I was changed. I didn’t look any different. My hair was still the same, my face was still the same, my body was still the same. But the day that I got saved, my heart was different, my attitude changed. That is what I think I like to key in on the most—my attitude was changed. It was no longer, “I don’t want to hear what God has to say!” It was, “Tell me more!” There was a changed attitude. I came to the Bible, I began to realize, “This isn’t right, and this isn’t right, and this isn’t right.” Over the long haul, here is my guarantee: I can look back over those years since 1971 and say, “There have been major changes in Doug Hammett’s life. He is not the same person that he was.”

So, yes, I have the promises of God, and I have the presence of God. But in case I might fool myself, God says, “I want you also to know there is the power of God that must be operative in your life.” And if you don’t have the power of God operative in your life, you better go back and check the presence and promises again, because they may not be for you. We will look at some of the changes we should see in our lives if we are saved.

We will love one another.

I John 3:14 says, “*We know that we have passed from death unto life, because we love the brethren. He that loveth not his brother abideth in death.*” Here the Bible says that one of the changes that will take place, one of the things that the power of God will do in

my life and in your life is that we will love each other. We'll care about one another. We'll give ourselves for one another. That's God's promise. If I have been born again there will be a love in my heart for other Christians.

We will keep His commandments.

In I John 2:3 it says, "*And hereby we do know that we know him, if we keep his commandments.*" If I am concerned about doing what God has to say that is another evidence that the power of God is operative in my life.

In another verse, I John 2:15, he says, "*Love not the world, neither the things that are in the world. If any man love the world, the love of the Father is not in him.*" I will turn from the world if I have really been born again. I will be able to look back on my life from the day that I got saved and be able to see that over those years I have been turning away from the world.

If you had walked up to me the day that I got saved and said, "Doug Hammett, you are a worldly person! These are the things you are going to have to drop out of your life," and then you had told me everything I was going to drop out of my life over those 18 years, I would have said to you, "I quit!"

But I can look back over those 18 years and I can say from day one, things started dropping out, things started changing. I started turning my back on this and that, and over the long haul there are major changes that have taken place. I look back and say, "God has overhauled me!" He hasn't gotten me all together yet, but He has overhauled me.

We will desire the Word of God.

And then I Peter 2:2 says, “*As newborn babes, desire the sincere milk of the word, that ye may grow thereby.*” The child of God, according to Matthew 5, ought to hunger and thirst after righteousness and after the Word of God.

So the way that I know that I am saved is, number one, I have the promises of God to count on. Number two, I have the presence of God. The Holy Spirit of God bears witness in my heart that I am saved. I can look back at a point of time in my life and say, “I did receive Jesus Christ!” Then, I have the power of God that is operative. Now, if you just been saved you don’t have this yet, because you haven’t been saved long enough, but over a period of time you will be able to look back to that salvation experience and say, “Over this period of time God has been operative in my life.”

Let me caution you here. There are people today who base their salvation simply on the “power of God.” But I remind you that salvation had to have a place to start in your life. There will be the promises of God when you receive Christ, and there will be the presence of God that’s operative and you will be able to go back and nail down that salvation experience. Maybe not with a date, but you will be able to say, “There has been this experience in my life when I received Jesus Christ.”

As you grow in your Christian life, you will be able to see the power of God working and changing you. That is His guarantee that it was a genuine experience, that you didn’t just say a few words, pray a prayer and walk away lost. You will be able to look over a period of time where God has changed your life and you can know you are born again. I remember asking Christ to save me, I also have a

Person who has been working in my life, and I have a changed lifestyle that is different than it was before.

CONCLUSION

So, you ask the question, “How can I know if I am saved or not?” And the answer is very simple. Tell me, have you received Christ? On the basis of the Word of God, did you understand that you were a sinner and that you deserved to go to Hell? Did you understand that you could not save yourself, you didn’t deserve anything that God would give you? Did you then know that Jesus Christ died for you, for your sins? And did you trust in Him alone to forgive you? Not your works, not your baptism, not your church membership, but Him alone. If you can point to that, if that is true in your life, then the promises of God are yours.

And the Spirit of God, as you read the Scriptures, takes those promises and makes them personal in your life. If you have been saved any length of time you are able to look from the point of salvation on, and over the long haul you are able to point to some fruit in your life and say, “Look at what’s been happening. I love to be here around the people of God, I love the Word of God, I love to live for God, and I have a desire to obey Him. I want His commandments operative in my life. I have turned from the things of this world. I don’t love this world like I once did. Oh, I must confess, I’m not as Godly as I wish, and I’m not as faithful as I wish, and I’m not as loving as I wish, but the fact is that there have been some major changes in my life.”

If you don’t have them, then you have to ask the question, “Was my first experience real or not?” That, my friend, is assurance of salvation.

QUESTIONS ON ASSURANCE

1. Can a person have full assurance of salvation?
2. Give the Bible reference proving the above answer.
3. What will be missing in our lives if we do not have assurance of salvation? (I John 1:4)
4. According to I John 3:21 God gives _____.
5. What gives proof that eternal life is a reality?
6. List some Bible references showing God's promise of eternal life.
7. Who does the "keeping" of our salvation?
8. Romans 5:5 tells us that the _____ comes to live within us when we are born again.
9. Does anything change when a person receives Christ, according to II Corinthians 5:17?
10. Is a person "perfect" at the moment of salvation?

11. Which of the following are evidences of God's power at work in a saved person's life:
- a. Love for other believers
 - b. Love for the world
 - c. Love for the Word of God

12. Have you received Jesus Christ as your personal Savior?

